A WORKING CHECKLIST

AUG 2026

Five Checks *That Lie*

Five green checkmarks. None of them proved what I thought they proved. I found all five in my own work, in one week. Not in someone else's.

RUN THESE AGAINST YOUR OWN STATUS CHECKS

In order. Each takes a few minutes and tells you honestly whether a green light means what you think it means.

01 The bill only I could see

LOOKS LIKE A test is an automatic checkbox your code has to clear before it ships. This one kept passing. It was quietly making a real, billed call to a live vendor every single time it ran.

VERIFY Cut the live connection and run the test again. If it still passes, it was never actually testing your work.

REAL PASS The test runs against a stand-in for the vendor, not the live paid service. A separate, clearly labeled test covers the real connection.

02 The link that goes nowhere

LOOKS LIKE A report said "done" and handed back a link. Nobody had opened it. The page behind it was empty.

VERIFY Open the link yourself. A link existing is not proof of what's on the other end.

REAL PASS The check confirms what's actually at the other end of the link, not just that a link got produced.

03 The demo only the demo team could run

LOOKS LIKE Every test passed inside the demo team's own setup. The moment someone ran it the way a real user would, outside that setup, it broke immediately.

VERIFY Hand it to someone outside the process. Watch them run it cold, in their own environment, not yours.

REAL PASS The test runs the way a real person actually encounters the thing, not inside a setup built just to make it pass.

04 The test that cannot fail

LOOKS LIKE The test data for a scanned-document tool was typed text, not an actual scan. Typed text is already machine-readable, so there was no way for that test to ever fail.

VERIFY Ask one plain question: what would actually make this test fail? If you can't answer that, it isn't testing anything.

REAL PASS The test runs on the same messy, real-world input the tool was built for: an actual scan, not a clean stand-in.

05 The fix that only fixed one copy

LOOKS LIKE A wrong number got corrected in one file and the ticket got closed. A second place that showed the same number, the one a customer actually saw, still had the old value.

VERIFY Check everywhere the value could show up to a real user, end to end, not just the one file someone happened to edit.

REAL PASS The value is correct wherever it's produced or displayed, not just wherever it happens to be stored.

> *"If a check has never failed, you have not verified that it works."*

Want the mechanics behind any of these? Ask Claude or ChatGPT to walk you through it. That part takes minutes, not days.

NEXT STEP

If one of these sounds familiar, I've probably already found it in someone else's pipeline too. **Book a free 20-minute brief** at **cal.com/este-val/audit-fit-call** and we'll work out what's actually true before you trust the next green light.

Want more of this first: **connect on LinkedIn**.

EV **Esteban V.**

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